

Hanyi Xu

Ph.D. Student | School of Communication | Florida State University

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My research examines how interactive media shape users' stress, motivation, and well-being. I study when enjoyable experiences become demanding and how design can support both engagement and restoration.

Education

Florida State University Aug. 2026 - Present
Doctor of Philosophy | Communication

Columbia University in the City of New York Aug. 2024 - Feb. 2026
Master of Arts | Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences

- Thesis: "Why Games Stop Feeling Fun: A Computational Approach to Emotional Demand in Play"
- Advisor: Dr. Gregory Kossinets

Syracuse University Aug. 2020 - May 2024
Bachelor of Science | Advertising (Minor Computer Engineering)

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles:

- [1] Boutros, E., Wu, Q., **Xu, H.**, & Fonger, N. L. (2023). Making mathematics meaningful: How learning about local social injustices develops undergraduate students' identity, intellect, skill, and criticality. *The Crown: Syracuse Undergraduate Research Journal*, 1, Article 16.

Conference Proceedings:

- [2] **Xu, H.**, Raja, W., Boutros, E., Wu, Q., & Fonger, N. L. (2024). Emotions in social justice mathematics: Students' experience from a college precalculus classroom. In K. W. Kosko, J. Caniglia, S. A. Courtney, M. Zolfaghari, & G. A. Morris (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Meeting of the North American Chapter of the International Group for the Psychology of Mathematics Education* (pp. 956–961). Kent State University.

Presentations

Talks:

- [1] **Xu, H.** (2024, April). *Making mathematics meaningful: A mixed-methods study of undergraduate students' learning through social justice*. Paper presented at the ACC Meeting of the Minds Conference, South Bend, IN.
- [2] Boutros, E., Fonger, N. L., Wu, Q., & **Xu, H.** (2023, December). *Making mathematics meaningful: How learning about local social injustices develops undergraduate students' identity, intellect, skill, and criticality*. Paper presented at the SOURCE Fall Research Expo, Syracuse

University, Syracuse, NY.

- [3] Boutros, E., Fonger, N. L., Wu, Q., & **Xu, H.** (2023, October). *Enhancing students' inclusion and belonging by developing meaningful mathematics literacy in the place we now call home*. Paper presented at the D.E.I.A. Symposium, Syracuse University, Syracuse, NY.

Posters:

- [4] **Xu, H.** (2026, May). *Demand overload: How game mechanics trigger stress and reduce enjoyment*. Poster accepted for presentation at the APS Annual Convention, Barcelona, Spain.
- [5] Rhee, V., Chen, Z., Gushiken, Y., Bakhru, K., **Xu, H.**, Bisbee, N., Li, Y., Tang, J. E., & Gordon, P. (2026, March). *Electrophysiological and behavioral indices of numerical perception and cognition*. Poster presented at the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Neuroscience Society, Vancouver, Canada.
- [6] Boutros, E., Fonger, N. L., Wu, Q., & **Xu, H.** (2023, August). *Making mathematics meaningful: How learning about local injustices develops undergraduate students' criticality, identities, intellect, skill, and emotion*. Poster presented at the SOURCE Symposium, Syracuse University, Syracuse, NY.

Honors and Awards

PME-NA Conference Scholarship, University of Missouri Conference Office

2024

Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant

May 2025 - Feb. 2026

Language and Cognitive Neuroscience Lab | Teachers College, Columbia University

Principal Investigator: Dr. Peter Gordon

- Develop automated sLORETA EEG analysis scripts using Python and MNE for 24 subjects to enable real-time 3D brain visualization.
- Design a configurable data pipeline supporting diverse cognitive tasks, including direction, size, and cardinality assessments.
- Operate EEG and eye-tracking instrumentation to facilitate rigorous data collection and maintain optimal signal quality.
- Analyze complex cognitive neuroscience concepts within a journal reading group to identify and apply relevant research methodologies.

Graduate Research Assistant

Oct. 2024 - May 2025

Cognitive Media Lab | UCSD/Columbia University

Principal Investigator: Dr. Michael Haupt

- Program and implement digital surveys to facilitate large-scale data collection for social research.
- Execute statistical analyses using Python and SPSS to model complex relationships via multiple regression and group comparisons.
- Evaluate socioeconomic and demographic correlations to identify systemic barriers to healthcare access.
- Author and revise manuscript sections to communicate findings for peer-reviewed publication.

Undergraduate Research Assistant

Apr. 2023 - May 2024

Meaningful Math Research Group | Syracuse University

Principal Investigator: Dr. Nicole Fonger

- Investigated the impact of social justice themes on critical thinking, identity, and academic engagement in precalculus students.
- Employed mixed methods (interviews and surveys) to gather and analyze data from 58 students at a predominantly white institution.
- Facilitated community events for "The Data Warriors" youth research program to foster community engagement.
- Synthesized qualitative data into academic manuscripts and presented findings at conferences including PME-NA 2024.

Undergraduate Research Assistant

Feb. 2022 - May 2022

The Sharpe Lab | Syracuse University

Principal Investigator: Dr. Charlotte Sharpe

- Applied qualitative research methodologies and ethical protocols to effectively study high school student attitudes toward teaching.
- Facilitated on-site focus groups and conducted semi-structured interviews to gather primary qualitative data.
- Analyzed interview transcripts to identify key thematic patterns regarding educational perspectives.
- Synthesized research findings to contribute to final project analysis and group discussions.

Teaching Experience

Florida State University

- Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Mass Media (MMC 2000) Fall 2026
- Teaching Assistant, Principles of Advertising (ADV 3008) Fall 2026

Columbia University

- Teaching Assistant, NLP for Social Sciences (QMSS GR5067) Spring/Summer/Fall 2025
Guided graduate students in implementing machine learning models and text analysis techniques to extract social insights from large-scale datasets.

Ningbo Landwave EDU

- Academic Tutor, TOEFL/SAT/A-Level Math Spring 2026
Conducted instructional sessions on standardized test logic and mathematical reasoning while managing systematic vocabulary assessments for college-bound students.

Syracuse University

- First Year Leader, First Year Seminar (FYS 101) Fall 2022, Fall 2023
Mentored undergraduate cohorts through their transition to university life by leading workshops on academic integrity and campus resource engagement.
- Calculus Facilitator, AEW for Calculus II (ECS 116) Fall 2021
Led collaborative problem-solving sessions to clarify complex integration techniques and series convergence for engineering and science majors.

Academic and Volunteer Service

Reviewer, PME-NA 2024

Jan. 2024

Skills

Programming & Data Tools: Python, R, SPSS, HTML, GitHub, MAXQDA

Marketing & Analytics Platforms: GWI, MRI Simmons, Nielsen Commspoint

Productivity & Office Tools: Microsoft Excel (certified in 2022), PowerPoint, Word; Apple Pages, Numbers, and Keynote; Google Workspace; Miro

Design & Media Tools: Adobe Photoshop, Premiere Pro, Canva

Computer Systems: Experienced user of Macintosh and Windows operating systems, with working knowledge of Linux and command-line interface (CLI) operations

Licenses & Certifications

RCR Social and Behavioral, CITI Program

Feb. 2026

Credential ID: 75318942

RECR for Faculty and Other Senior Personnel, CITI Program

Feb. 2026

Credential ID: 75318943

Human Subjects Protection SBR, CITI Program

Aug. 2025 - Aug. 2028

Credential ID: 71361914

FDA-Regulated Research, CITI Program

Aug. 2025

Credential ID: 71361915

Research With Minors SBR, CITI Program

Aug. 2025

Credential ID: 71361916

Microsoft Office Specialist: Excel 2019 Associate, Microsoft

Nov. 2022

Credential ID: n28K-Dwo5

Industry Experience

AI Research Intern

Apr. 2026 - June 2026

Shengcubic (Beijing) Public Relations Consulting Co., Ltd. | Ningbo, China

- Researched Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) strategies by analyzing how AI engines such as ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Doubao crawl, cite, and present brand content, then translated findings into actionable content and technical optimization recommendations.
- Conducted comparative evaluations of AI models, including DeepSeek, Qwen, GPT, and Claude, for content generation, video production, and coding support, and developed practical criteria for model selection across different use cases.
- Built and deployed a GEO Audit platform from concept to launch, including a Vue 3 + Vite frontend, Express backend, Playwright-based crawling engine, and a 7-dimension website scoring system based on Google Quality Rater Guidelines and WCAG 2.2 standards.
- Designed an AI-powered WeChat content pipeline for three medical and technology accounts, integrating DeepSeek, NewsAPI.ai, and Pexels to support news aggregation, AI-assisted drafting, image matching, human review, and publication.

Account Executive Intern

June 2024 - Aug. 2024

Shanghai Blue Universe Digital Technology Co., Ltd. | Shanghai, China

- Coordinate workflow and timeline management for the Sony Camera Line Promotion across RED and Bilibili platforms.
- Streamline internal communication by synthesizing client feedback to accelerate article production and monitor traffic.
- Analyze market share performance of new releases using Power BI to inform strategic campaign adjustments.
- Execute project initiation, finalization, and contract documentation to ensure compliance with internal procedures.

Marketing and Media Intern

June 2023 - Aug. 2023

Boathouse Group Inc | Waltham, MA

- Led media optimization analysis for the Story District Promotion Campaign within a collaborative five-person team.
- Analyzed social media metrics and competitor data to accurately assess campaign effectiveness.
- Developed content calendars and designed performance KPIs to track engagement goals.
- Produced a strategic media plan selected by the client over competing proposals.
- Delivered data-driven recommendations to enhance PR strategy and utilized Hub tools for project management.

Associate Producer

Mar. 2023 - May 2024

Orange Television Network | Syracuse, NY

- Directed visual storytelling, crew training, and on-set operations for the TV program *Psych vs. Star*.
- Managed post-production quality control, including title design and final cut supervision, to ensure broadcast standards.
- Developed and maintained production schedules to ensure timely project delivery.
- Executed single-camera production logistics for *Loud and Clear*, handling camera operation and site management.

Language

Chinese (Mandarin): Native

English: Fluent